



ANJALI BHAGWAT

Former Olympian shooter and multiple World Cup medal winner



WINNING MINDSET OF INDIAN SHOOTERS WILL BE KEY IN PARIS

Our shooters' exploits in 2023 make me **hopeful** for the upcoming Paris Olympics.

An unfortunate show in the Rio and Tokyo Olympics saw major upheavals in the Indian shooting set-up.

The ripple effects are still being felt, with shooters like Abhishek Verma and Saurabh Chaudhary struggling to find a place among the country's top 10. Even Manu Bhaker and Divyansh Panwar took time to regain form. Rahi Sarnobat, the country's best hope in 25m pistol in Tokyo, had to take an extended injury break.

There was light, however, at the end of the tunnel. Although a few waved the sport goodbye, many dedicated the COVID downtime to specialised training. After the Olympics, every competition threw up new winners. Shooters like Tilottama Sen, Hriday Hazarika, Rhythm Sangwan, and Esha Singh emerged on the stage. Once again, the domestic field gave us a reason to smile. There were performances of note, not only from the rifle and pistol shooters but by the shotgun wielders as well.

Our shooters' exploits in 2023 make me hopeful for the upcoming Paris Olympics. There are a reasonable number of quotas already in hand. There are quite a few medals and records that we have bagged in World Cups and World Championships.

The shooters must now prepare for the new-format domestic Olympic trials, where the quota holders have a negligible advantage.

In events like air rifle men and women, only decimals separate the shooters. Thereby, with every passing competition, the standings, which will eventually determine the participation of these athletes in these

trials, are getting affected. Some shooters who missed out on a quota have a higher ranking than quota winners. There are a few shooters who have a good conversion rate in the final, while others have been consistently notching up good qualification scores.

The competition is arguably the tightest in men's 10m air rifle between Rudranksh Balasaheb Patil, Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, Arjun Babuta, and Divyansh Singh Panwar.

The hovering uncertainty is putting additional pressure on shooters. Indeed, it must be a stressful period for them, but we have always wanted a challenging but world-class standard when it comes to our bench strength. At the same time, the federation is trying its level best to support the shooters wholeheartedly.

Although everything seems to be going well, in a sport like shooting, it is hard to predict results. And the Olympics is a different ball game altogether; it has that special aura. I believe one's stars need to align to be on the podium. Everything must fall into place on that day. After the disappointment of the past two Olympics, I would prefer to wait and watch before making a prediction.

However, I am so proud and confident about our team, which has more than 70 per cent shooters in their youth, having the advantage of good fitness and quick reflexes. They are intelligent, smart, aggressive, and have a positive attitude. They know how to win, and this winning mindset can work miracles in the Olympics. Let's cross our fingers and give our champions positive vibes to excel at the topmost platform in the world.